

HASHKAMA WEEKLY



SHEMINI ATZERES EDITION 5787

By Reb Gemini on Simchas Torah **חכמה ב-א תאמין?**

Consider the following “Torah” thought, generated by Gemini:

Did the AI get it

right?

Do you find it to be accurate?

Or did the technology miss the boat?

Question

Chosheve rabosai, morai v’rabbosai, and to the three bochurim who are currently hiding in the ezras nashim to avoid being called up for pesichah. We are about to celebrate Simchas Torah, and we are faced with a gevaldige kasha. If you think about the teva of human beings, we usually celebrate a siyum when we achieve eppes for the very first time. Alternatively, we celebrate if we somehow break a world record. If Shmerel finally finishes Shas after forty years of shiurim, we make a massive seudah. We buy him a silver becher. We pretend to enjoy the spicy herring. But if Shmerel finishes Shas again the very next year, we give him a hearty yasher koach, we hand him a dry piece of kokosh cake from the back of the kiddush room, and we all go home. Nobody throws a massive parade for doing the exact same thing you did twelve months ago. Yet, every single year, we finish V’Zos HaBeracha, we make a massive tumult, we dance with the Sifrei Torah until our kneecaps require serious medical intervention, and we act like this is a chiddush gadol. Why the immense simcha if we already did this last year?

Chelek Aleph: The Chiddush of Amal

The first terutz lies in the very nature of ameilus baTorah. When a person reads a regular sefer, once he reaches the back cover, he knows the plot. He knows that the butler did it. There is no reason to read it again, let alone dance with it around a bimah. However, the Nefesh HaChaim (Shaar Daled, Perek Yud-Aleph) explains that the Torah is intrinsically connected to the oros of Hakadosh Baruch Hu. Because Hakadosh Baruch Hu is an ain sof, His Torah is similarly an ain sof. It is mamash impossible to read the same Torah twice. Every time we learn a pasuk, our own madreigah has shifted. The Yid who reads Bereishis this year is fundamentally not the same Yid who read Bereishis last year. Over the past twelve months, you have experienced nisyonos, you have grown, you have survived another one of the gabai’s appeals during yizkor, and your sechel has evolved. Therefore, the Torah you are completing is literally a new Torah. You are discovering havanos that were completely inaccessible to you last year. The Malbim (Hakdamah to Yeshaya) discusses how the depth of a pasuk expands based on the daas of the reader. So, we are not celebrating a repeated accomplishment. We are celebrating a world record! It is your own personal world record. You have plumbed depths of ameilus that did not exist in the bria until you learned them this year. We dance because the Torah we just finished is a brand new sefer, completely unique to the tekufah we are currently in. When the baal korei leins those final pesukim, he is revealing a totally new ohr. We rejoice because we did not just reread an old text. We uncovered a chiddush that the Ribbono Shel Olam hid specifically for us to find right now. This is why the simcha is so profound. We are not cheering for a static finish line. We are cheering for the limitless depth of the tachlis of our existence. We are celebrating that no matter how many times we turn the tzettel, there is always another machshavah waiting for us to uncover. So, when you take that sefer in your arms, remember that you are holding the ultimate chiddush. This requires a profound level of simcha, at least until the chazzan decides to add another fifteen minutes to the davening with his niggunim.

Chelek Bais: The Simcha of Kiddushin

Let us suggest a second terutz to our original kasha. To understand this, we have to examine the nature of our keshet with the Torah. If the Torah is merely a chochmah, then finishing it a second or third time does not warrant a massive Yom Tov. If you master physics, you do not throw a party every October just to remind everyone you still know physics. However, the Midrash Tanchuma (Ki Tisa, Os Lamed-Vov) makes a gevaldige diyuk. The pasuk says that Moshe Rabbeinu received the luchos “k’chalo.” The Midrash points out that this is written chaser, without a vov, so it can be read as “k’kallato,” meaning like a kallah. The Torah is not a textbook; it is our kallah. Our kabalas haTorah was a maamad of kiddushin. Now, let us think about how we celebrate a chasunah. When a chassan and kallah get married, there is a massive simcha. But what happens a year later? They celebrate an anniversary. Yankel, assuming he wants peace in his bayis, will stop at the local kosher supermarket, buy a slightly wilted bouquet of flowers that costs triple what it should, and wish his aishes chayil a happy anniversary. Why? They are not getting married for the first time! They did not break a world record! They are celebrating because an anniversary is not about acknowledging a new accomplishment. It is about celebrating the hemshech of a relationship. It is a reaffirmation of the kiddushin. The Beis HaLevi (Drashos, Drasha Ches) explains that our relationship with the Torah is entirely based on this concept of ishus. We are not students reviewing a curriculum; we are a chassan rejoicing with our kallah. On Simchas Torah, we are not celebrating that we finished reading a long document. We are celebrating our anniversary. When a couple reaches another year of nissuin, they look back at the challenges they overcame, the late nights, the times they had to compromise, and the beautiful peiros of their bayis neeman. Similarly, when we finish the Torah again, we are looking back at a whole year of early morning daf yomi shiurim, of fighting off the yetzer hara....

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.....who tells us to sleep in, of struggling to understand a difficult Rashba, and of making time for sedarim when our parnasah demands our attention. We are celebrating the dedication it takes to keep this marriage vibrant and fully alive. Therefore, the simcha is mamash appropriate. We dance in a circle because the wedding ring itself is an iggul. When we hold the Sifrei Torah during hakafo, we are essentially dancing at our own chasunah all over again. We are reminding Hakadosh Baruch Hu that despite all the distractions of the gashmius around us, our ahavah for His Torah remains just as fresh as it was by Har Sinai. We are renewing our kesubah. We are declaring that we still choose this shidduch above all other chochmos in the entire bria. So, while breaking a world record is a nice reason for a party, a wedding anniversary is an even better one. We rejoice with the Torah because we are deeply in love with it. It is our tachlis and our chayim. And much like a successful marriage, it requires constant avodah, tremendous patience, and the ability to ignore the gabai when he tells you to hurry up and finish your shmoneh esrei. The simcha we feel is the sheer joy of knowing that this shidduch is for netzach, standing the test of time perfectly, and we get to celebrate our anniversary with the most magnificent kallah every single year without fail, forever and ever. May we all be zocheh to feel this profound ahavah every single time we open a sefer.

Chelek Gimmel: The Iggul Without an End

We now arrive at a third terutz to explain our massive simcha for an accomplishment we already completed last year. Let us look at the halachah. The Tur (Orach Chaim, Siman Tof-Reish-Kuf-Tes) writes that as soon as we finish reading V'Zos HaBeracha, we must immediately begin reading Bereishis. Why? Because we do not want to give the Satan an opportunity to be mekatreg and say, "Look at the Yidden, they are thrilled to finally be finished with the Torah!" To prevent this kitrug, we immediately show that we are not actually finished at all. We are simply starting again. But this halachah reveals a much deeper yesod about what we are actually celebrating. Human beings celebrate a siyum when a project is completely done. When the shul's building committee finally finishes the renovations after seven years of arguments and three different contractors, we make a kiddush. The simcha is that the job is finally over and we no longer have to listen to the president's speeches about the carpet colors. But Torah is fundamentally different. The Maharal (Tiferes Yisroel, Perek Mem-Gimmel) explains that the Torah is compared to an iggul, a perfect circle, which possesses neither a beginning nor an end. When you read a regular sefer, it is a straight line. You start at point aleph and you finish at point tof. Once you hit the final page, the journey is over. But a circle never ends. Our simcha on Simchas Torah is not a celebration of finishing; it is a celebration of the exact opposite! We are rejoicing over the fact that it is absolutely impossible to ever finish the Torah. We are celebrating the infinity of the chochmah. This is why our primary minhag on Simchas Torah is hakafo, dancing in an endless circle. Have you ever watched the hakafo in our shul? It is a spectacle of spiraling chaos. The gabbaim are trying to keep the circle moving, the older balabatim are standing in the middle trying not to get trampled, and the children are running around searching for the legendary candy man who disappeared into the coatroom. But the chaos of the circle is exactly the point. The circle represents the ain sof. We finish the final pasuk of Devarim, and instead of closing the sefer and patting ourselves on the back, we immediately loop right back into the first pasuk of Bereishis. We are overjoyed that we are trapped in this magnificent loop. If we could actually finish the Torah, it would imply that the Torah is finite. It would mean that Hakadosh Baruch Hu gave us a chochmah that has limits, chas v'shalom. The fact that we read it year after year, looping endlessly from V'Zos HaBeracha back to Bereishis, is the greatest proof of its elokus. We are throwing a party because we serve a Ribbono Shel Olam whose chochmah is so vast that we can spend our entire lives swimming in it without ever reaching the shore. This is the ultimate reason we do not need to break a world record to celebrate. The very fact that there is no finish line is the record itself! So, when you are sweating through your kapote while circling the bimah for the seventh time, remember what you are physically acting out. You are mimicking the eternity of the Torah. You are showing the Satan, and yourself, that a Yid's journey in ruchnius has no stop signs. We never finish, and that is precisely why we never stop dancing. The loop itself is our greatest bracha, shielding us from the emptiness of a finite world. It is an endless simcha for an endless Torah, bringing pure kedushah into our lives.

Chelek Daled: The Synthesis of Simchas Torah

Rabosai, if we take a step back and look at the three mehalchim we have just developed, we can construct a gevaldige synthesis that defines not just Simchas Torah, but the entire essence of a Yid. In Chelek Aleph, we learned from the Nefesh HaChaim that ameilus baTorah creates a totally new chiddush every year. In Chelek Bais, we saw from the Beis HaLevi that our keshar to the Torah is an ishus, a marriage that requires constant reaffirmation. And in Chelek Gimmel, the Maharal taught us that the Torah is an iggul, an infinite loop without a finish line. When we weave these three yesodos together, we gain a breathtaking new havanah of what we are celebrating today. We are not merely dancing because we read a lot of words, nor are we celebrating a standard milestone. We are rejoicing over the paradox of our tachlis! The synthesis is this: We are locked in an eternal marriage (the iggul) with a kallah whose depth is so limitless that she transforms into someone completely new every single year (the chiddush), provided we put in the daily effort to understand her (the ishus). This is the ultimate world record! Where else in the bria can you find a relationship that never ends, yet never gets stale? In the gashmiyusdike world, anything that repeats endlessly becomes terribly boring—just ask anyone who has tasted the shul's cholent three weeks in a row. But in ruchnius, the Torah manages to be both an eternal circle and a constant chiddush simultaneously. Because Hakadosh Baruch Hu is infinite, our marriage to His chochmah is an endless loop of new discoveries. We celebrate because this is the only endeavor in the entire universe where you can run in a circle and still move forward. This is the profound kavanah we should have when we pick up the Sifrei Torah today. We are holding an endless, ever-renewing kesubah. So, as we prepare for hakafo, let us make sure our simcha matches this monumental realization. Let us dance with genuine hislahavus, let us forgive the gabai for whatever aliyah we end up getting, and let us remember how incredibly fortunate we are to be trapped in this beautiful loop. Gut Yom Tov, and please, try not to drop the sticky candy on the new carpets.

Friday (Hoshana Rabah)

6:18 pm הדלקה
6:25 pm שקיעה

Shabbus (Shemini Atzeres)

(8:45)/7:15 am שחרית/יזכור (Not Before)
2:30 pm מנחה
7:13 pm הדלקה (50)

Sunday (Simchas Torah)

6:55 pm שחרית
8:13 pm מעריב (52)
7:14/7:23/7:33/7:45 pm צה"כ (8.5/50/60/72)